COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Head of Business Technology at *Notion* Labs Believes *Decagon* Leads in Support Automation with Strong Integration and Cost Efficiency

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
13 Aug 2026	15 May 2026	Customer	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	DECAGON.AI

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The conversation focused on the evaluation, selection, and ongoing use of Decagon as a customer support automation tool, including comparisons with competitors, integration depth, pricing models, and the impact on support operations and costs.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Head of Business Technology with nearly three years of experience overseeing go-to-market, G&A, and business essentials engineering systems, including integration, automation, and AI engineering, with direct responsibility for evaluating and implementing customer support technologies.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- **The expert is optimistic about the future of advanced support automation tools**, particularly Decagon, Sierra, and Fin, seeing them as likely leaders in the space if current trends continue.
- The expert values innovation and proactive product development, emphasizing the importance of headless integration and customer memory features for future digital strategies.
- While satisfied with Decagon's current performance, the expert remains open to switching if a competitor offers significantly superior headless integration capabilities.

TAKEAWAYS

- The expert led a comprehensive RFP process, evaluating Decagon and several competitors (including Sierra, Fin, Ada, Forethought, Intercom) across chat, email, integrations, analytics, technology roadmap, and partnership support.
- **Decagon was chosen over competitors due to its strong performance in chat and rapid improvements in email, as well as ease of use and support for non-technical teams**.
- The expert's organization uses Decagon as the first line of defense for chat and email support, achieving over 60% automation in chat resolution and aiming for 70-75%.
- Switching between support platforms is relatively easy unless deep integrations are in place, which can create a stronger moat for the incumbent provider.
- **The expert has seen a 75% reduction in offshore support vendor costs** due to Decagon's automation, though internal support headcount has remained stable for higher-touch needs.

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Table of Contents

Introduction and Background

Current Usage and Future Vision

Pricing and Competitor Analysis

Tool Evaluation and Market Trends

Integration, Challenges, and Future Outlook

Expert Bio

Head of Business Technology at Notion Labs, a customer of Decagon. Head of Business Technology at Notion Labs. The expert is responsible overseeing all internal systems and tools that support company-wide operations. The expert's team manages go-to-market systems, customer support tools, and the broader marketing tech stack, including platforms like Customer.io, ZoomInfo, and Salesforce. The expert is responsible for all finance systems, legal CRMs, and HR tools, ensuring seamless integration and scalability across departments. The expert can consult on go-to-market technologies, salesforce, Marcheto, ZoomInfo, and Customer.io.

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Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Thank you for speaking with us about Decagon.ai. Would love to jump in and just quickly get a background on your role at ***Notion*** and of how you oversee your internal systems, then really want to talk about ***Decagon***. ow did you evaluate it the first time? How does it compare against competitors, and really where, if anywhere, there's stickiness to the product and where you see it going from here? Just to start, background would be fantastic.

Expert 00:00:29

Sure. I joined Notion almost three years back in the business technology. I oversee three groups. One is go-to-market system, so that would be marketing, sales, CS, and CX systems, then also oversee G&A systems, so finance, legal, and HR. Lastly, business essentials engineering, that takes care of our integration engineering, automation, and AI engineering as well. We looked at Decagon now almost two years back.

Before that, we had Forethought. We replaced Forethought with Decagon. Over that time, we've evaluated a bunch of tools, but in the last year, we've reviewed Decagon against Pylon, Sierra, Intercom Fin or Fin now, and a few others as well. Last month, we were doing a POC with Sierra to do a comparison on the headless side of things. I can detail as much as you want.

Client 00:01:30

Perfect. I will certainly have a couple of questions. Maybe just to start with, so you had Forethought to begin with, what drove you to do either POC with Decagon or others and to make the switch from Forethought? Was it just a general, let's make sure we have the best in the market, or was there an issue at Forethought that drove that change?

Expert 00:01:51

Yeah. Initially, Forethought came on my radar, I wasn't really focusing, we had a CX analyst, I had just joined, I was actually doing my budget review for next year, so maybe two, three months into my role, and I saw a pretty big renewal number against Forethought. Just to give you a bit of my background, I come from Intercom Fin, or I've worked at Intercom, so I know pricing and how much it should be. When I saw the pricing for renewal, things did not connect well for me.

I asked my analyst to do a deep dive to understand the ROI. He came back to me within one week, and he says, "The data is really messy." I don't even know if you can call it a return of investment because **it was a deficit in investment**, more like it. The technology was being held by the analyst and two other people on the CX team. We asked them to come in. I wanted to see their roadmap for the future. When they did present it, their VP of product and all that, it felt like they didn't have a good enough vision to be at the forefront of where I think this technology was going to go.

At that point, we decided, "You know what? let's look at what's out there." We did a full-on RFP. We looked at Aisera, Sierra, Yellow, 14.ai, Forethought, Ultimate, Decagon, and Intercom as well. We did a full RFP with them, and ended up going with Decagon.

Client 00:03:20

That is really helpful background. I think you've got an incredible knowledge of the industry, and so I want to go, and I want to really dig into Decagon versus some of these competitors. Before we go there, you mentioned the product roadmap wasn't what you envisioned for the future of this product. Could you give me a sense for what you're using Decagon for today, and then when you think about your ideal end state, what are you looking for moving forward? What would you want on that product's roadmap?

Expert 00:03:49

Okay. This will be a bit of a long dialogue on my end. Currently, what we're using Decagon for is our support. For support, we have two channels. We have chat and we have email. We don't have voice. We don't support voice. It's more of a cultural thing for ***Notion*** than anything else. Those are the two channels. ***Decagon*** is our first line of defense, so if someone comes in either chat or email, ***Decagon*** takes a look, and based on the AOPs that we've set, it will either respond or if it's a tier one customer, we'll route it directly to a human. That's what we're using Decagon for at the moment.

Where I think and where we are heading towards for the future is, these systems are becoming, I call it more of a digital landscape strategy than anything else, is we want to think about not just when a customer asks us to react. We want to get to a world where we're not looking at the deflection rates, but we're looking at what are the things that didn't even hit our support queue.

For that to happen, we want to know and understand the customer from the very moment they step into our online platform. On our websites, we want to make sure now the same technology, let's say Decagon, is embedded on our landing pages as well, so the sales and marketing funnel can come from there. One of the other underlying technologies that we're looking and thinking through with Decagon and even Sierra as well is to have customer memory being built in. Every customer that comes in, from that point onwards, we track.

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The next journey that we are thinking through with this entire, call it, Decagon and Sierra as well, is a headless integration, which that means is when, let's say they've come onto our landing page, they've answered, they really like the product, they get into the product as well. We now know who they are because of the customer memory layer, but then also through the headless, we can then interact into our Notion's own native product to prompt them. Instead of them prompting us, we know why they came in.

We can start to prompt them and say, "Hey, you should be setting up a database, and here's how we can help you set up a database," or "We see you trying to do A, B, and C and D. You haven't finished this out. Here's what we're going to do," so more proactive, call it pushes inside the product as well. It doesn't matter where you go outside the product, inside the product to support. One, we have a full life cycle of what you've done and understanding of your customer journey. This way, even when it is reactive, **our reaction is a lot better** than it was maybe a year back.

Client 00:06:28

That's incredible. How much of that push is coming from your team versus from Decagon and Sierra trying to pull their product to be that next layer? To phrase it a different way, how close is the product to being able to solve that you are on a landing page, you're trying to create a chart X, Y, Z, and it's able to push a solution to you? How far away do you sense that the product is, and is that something that Decagon's actively trying to solve on its own?

Expert 00:06:55

It is our strategy, but I think it is a broad strategy across the market because Sierra has the headless integration, and they were thinking through those lens maybe six months, eight months back. Decagon just released their headless maybe two months back, I believe. They understand that this is going to become a race of either horizontal or vertical.

I think both Sierra and Decagon are the two companies that I see that are going more horizontal. I think Pylon is as well. These two companies are going more in that direction than deep vertical. Of course, they have deep vertical. Sierra has a much deeper vertical integration as well. I just think they both knew this is what's going to happen in the next six months to a year. More and more customers are going to be asking for it.

Client 00:07:48

That's helpful. Could you provide any context as to how you would think about pricing for the headless model? Customer support, from our understanding, it's a certain X cents per chat. Is it similar this push model or the headless model? How does the pricing work there?

Expert 00:08:07

It's the exact same. It's a conversation per models. They tried to give me a different pricing, but I was like, "Nope, I'm not going to negotiate a different price for headless." We are at the same pricing level at the moment.

Client 00:08:25

Got it. Would a customer have to interact, and apologies for my lack of knowledge on the headless piece, so if I'm on the website, I'm going to get a pop-up chat that says, "Do you need help with X, Y, Z?" and then I would have to respond to that in order for a conversation to be started and for it to register a payment or to start the tally or the conversation?

Expert 00:08:46

The way we view conversations is we view them as meaningful conversations. If you come in and you go, "What is one + one?" that we will not count as meaningful at all. If you bounce within five seconds, you come in and you open up the chat window, and then you get out, that also will not count as a meaningful conversation because you didn't ask anything that would react, really needed it.

Client 00:09:10

That's incredibly helpful. Would love to go back. I know you listed a larger list of all the players in the space. You used to work at Fin, so just incredible background. Would be great to understand why you went with Decagon, what stood out about that product, and then maybe just talk to the extent you've got an understanding of the pros and cons of some of these other tools in the space. Be incredibly helpful as we try to get our head around the landscape.

Expert 00:09:41

We did a pretty thorough RFP in terms of what we wanted to see, what we wanted to take a look at. Our RFP was broken down into four categories. One was chat, and what we did with chat was we looked at three things. We looked at, one, we had, call it, preemptive 100-odd questions broken down into eight different categories. Call it 100 questions which are a good subset of what we expect to get, and then

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eight broad categories inside of it. Roughly each category had 10 or 12 questions.

What we did was we gave Decagon and all these vendors that I talked about access to our knowledge base, and then we send them these questions and we looked at the responses. We scored them accordingly. Second thing we did was we also looked at AOPs and how easy or difficult it is to set up these operating processes for these systems. There were three categories, but those two were the main categories. Same thing went for email. The other broader category was integrations and analytics.

The fourth one was around technology and roadmap and partnerships, which isWe wanted to evaluate them on what their future roadmap looks like. Are they just swimming or are they really pushing the needle forward? Lastly, from a partnership perspective, how much support are we willing to get from them as we talk?

I'll also even help you with the scoring as well. The top three that came from a response perspective was Decagon and Sierra were neck to neck. They were at 94% or 90%-94%, call it score that we got from the responses for both chat. Ada and Fin were, call it, I think between 80%-90%, and then the rest were at 50%. There was a big step order difference between the, call it, three categories that were looked at.

On the email side, **Sierra and Ada were the best**. Decagon wasn't, but by the time we had finished up the RFP, they had pushed out a bunch of changes to really push these things forward, and it became at par with Decagon. Why we ended up going between Decagon and Sierra? Sierra at that time was looking for more volume, and I think also it was more engineering heavy on how they were thinking of implementation from both AOP perspective.

I don't think the UI was where it was today. It wasn't, call it, very human-friendly or for the CX team to be self-serve. I would have to need a couple of technical folks on my team to really manage it. I didn't have that at that point, so we decided to part ways mutually and move forward. At the end, it became Decagon, Fin, and Ada.

Fin or call it Intercom, the reason we didn't decide to go with it because before I had joined, **they had a pretty sour moment with them**. Even though the technology was good, I think our head of CX was a bit jaded, so we decided to part ways with them as well. We were left basically with Ada, Decagon, and we kept Forethought because it was incumbent. We went throught that, but eventually we realized Decagon was head and shoulders above the other two.

Client 00:12:59

Got it. It sounded like, and apologies if I'm incorrect here, that you're currently going and reevaluating some tools right now. Did I hear that correctly?

Expert 00:13:11

Yeah. Last year we were in the process of evaluating tools on a constant basis in the space because it was changing so dramatically. We've looked at Maven, we looked at Pylon. We looked at Poly. We looked at Fin again just to evaluate. When we ran into Sierra and Bret Taylor came and presented to us, it felt like they're thinking. They were on the headless side in October, November. The way they were presenting, it fit our digital strategy the best, so we decided to do a proof of concept with them as well.

Client 00:13:48

Got it. Are you currently using Sierra, or are you on Decagon?

Expert 00:13:54

No. We did Sierra POC but we are on Decagon. We wanted to just test Sierra out.

Client 00:14:03

That makes sense. Do you envision that being the process moving forward is every six to twelve months doing a relatively constant reevaluation of the tools?

Expert 00:14:14

No. I think this year we might not do as many. Last year, things were changing dramatically, but I think where we are going to head with our digital landscape and strategy, we're set for another year or two.

Client 00:14:28

Got it. Have you evaluated building an internal tool like this?

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Expert 00:14:33

Yes. It takes a village to build that out. There's a lot of things. We have our own Notion product. One of the pushes that our CEO is saying, "Why can't we do this?" It's not as simple as, we have a chatbot, we have LLM underneath it, and let's go build it out. There is a lot of things that go underneath the hood, which requires a lot of maintenance and management. At the end of the day, when you do all of that, you call it the build versus buy. When we've done the math, the build was a lot more expensive.

It doesn't seem expensive because you are like, "I can move fast." The reality was for building a product of that quality to maintain the level of quality that we would need, we would need a few engineers on this on an ongoing basis, which makes **the ROI a lot worse** because Sierra and Decagon would be a lot cheaper at that point.

Client 00:15:30

Got it. Could you provide a ballpark of just generally what the spend looks like for a company of your size? Is it $20,000 a month? Is it $100,000 a month? Is it $1 million? Maybe something that I could think about what this tool would cost for a standard company.

Expert 00:15:54

It's different because it depends on the volume of conversations you're going to have. To give you an idea, I think Intercom's a pretty good open model, so I can talk about it. It's one figure per deflection. That's the number they've gone after. You can negotiate, you can get down to, call it, less than $2 if you negotiate well with them. That's the price you're looking at.

Talking to our CFO, that's the number I give her. I'm like, "Here's our deflection rate, here's our number for this product, and here's how much it's going to cost us because our thought process is, these are the number of conversations we're going to have in this particular year," and she has an insight into our, call it, offshore model cost us 4X to 7X more expensive than what Decagon costs us. From that perspective, it's a win-win. To give you a ballpark figure, it's around six figures.

Client 00:16:51

That's incredibly helpful. I appreciate that. When you were at Fin, as you thought about going back a little bit towards the product roadmap, do you have a sense for, is there a point in the future where there's only a couple of these companies? Right now, it's a massive landscape, a bunch of people, as we've talked about, leapfrogging each other. Just based on your experience, where do you envision this market going? Will there always be a ton of people because there's relatively low barriers to entry? Does it consolidate? What would your ideal be as a customer for what this looks like?

Expert 00:17:28

There's going to be two things that are going to happen. It's going to be commoditized quite a bit, this entire market. **That commodity market is going to be very messy for the long tail**. For the SMB mid-market, **it's going to be very, very messy** because the bar to entry to building out the support tools is very easy. When I say easy, easy for a product team if you want to build that out. You can get that going fairly fast, really robustly.

However, I feel like there is going to be two or three or four **that are going to be very, very strong on this perspective**. There's going to be a bunch of system of records underneath it trying to win that entire business, the entire vertical, all the way from chat to a ticketing system as we go.

You'll have three categories. You'll have categories that are long tail, which are just support apps that are going to be very cheap, "Hey, if Intercom is going to charge you $1, we'ill charge you $0.20, $0.30." A lot of SMBs are going to move in that direction because they are going to be very, very money-conscious. There's going to be like, "I already have Sales Cloud, I already have Freshworks, I already have ServiceNow. Do I need the best in class to come in and integrate? That's going to be a lot of headache. No, we're going to stick with them."

There's going to be a lot of companies that are going to be like, "No, this is a new operating system of the future. A lot of those would be the three, four. I picture Sierra being there, Decagon being there, and Fin being there as well. Fin, I might be more biased than anything else, but I will call that out. Fin, I see them in the same category.

Client 00:19:14

Got it. On the switching, how difficult is it to move between systems? I know you moved from Forethought to Decagon, but especially as you build out and add headless. Does that create a little bit more of a moat if you start adding the customer data?

Expert 00:19:31

Without the headless, without other verticals only support, moving away from them is not that difficult. It's actually pretty straightforward. You can do it within a month from a chat support side. All of these tools, we talked to Sierra, that was our very first conversation, which was, how

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does the migration process work? They are like, "You have Decagon's AOP."

What they've also done, by the way, both Decagon, Sierra, and Fin are all doing is building out migration tools for each other. They're like, "Yeah, we want to rip away from a couple of logos from Sierra. We have this tool that can replace all their functionality. Within a week or two, you can be live." However, the other complication is if you have deeper integrations with other products like Stripe, Salesforce, internal tooling, then the moat becomes heavier and heavier, and then the migration becomes heavier and heavier.

Client 00:20:32
Got it. Does Decagon have some of those integrations? How deeply embedded has that tool been able to make itself into your systems and just in general, the industry?

Has Decagon been able to do integrations with some of your internal tools to make it more difficult to switch?

Expert 00:20:51
No. They spent quite some bit of time with us in setting up these integrations. I think between us, they also know that that is one of the bigger moats that they have.

Client 00:21:03
That's helpful. I know that we are running up on time here, but just during the integration process, was it relatively good white-glove service? Maybe just your thoughts on the team and how easy it was to get up and running with Decagon, how supportive they've been since then?

Expert 00:21:21
Their team in the initial year was fantastic, us getting up and running within one month, I believe, less than a month. The onboarding team, the forward-deployed engineers, they were spot on. They were as good as it gets at that time. The experience that we had was phenomenal. However, as scaling issues go, as companies become very successful, they start to rapidly grow. With rapidly, you get a lot more accounts assigned to you, a lot more issues starting to creep up because the platforms are getting stretched. The second year with Decagon was rough, both from a technology perspective but also from a perspective of, what's the right word, people side as well. **Both had a lot of growing pains**.

That was also why we continued to look. We were finding a lot more gaps last year than anything else. We had a pretty open conversation with person A and their team. I was pretty straightforward with them what we would expect as we move forward. If they were to show up, then we would. Otherwise, we were figuring out our other options as well.

Client 00:22:30
That's helpful. What would it take for you to switch from Decagon at this point? If you've got someone who's marginally better, would you switch, or is there a certain capability?

Expert 00:22:41
Yeah. I think the one follow that I had made to our head of CX, the only time I would plan on moving is if the headless integration with Decagon was **below** par by a bit from Sierra. If it was, then that would be the one that would make us go, "Okay, we need to make a change." As far as deflection rates are concerned, I think we're at a pretty decent clip with Decagon. To marginally improve our, let's say, either NPS score or deflection rates, would not be worth us switching over.

Client 00:23:12
That's helpful, appreciate that. I know that we've talked a little bit about the headless, the future state. Could **you talk about some of the more difficult use cases** that you would need a solution like Decagon that has high-end engineers in the background versus something that a company could build just with an LLM internally to support, like a typical chat feature? Just to rephrase the question, sorry, I asked that a little bit confusingly. What's the level of complexity that Decagon solves?

Expert 00:23:44
I think it's not the, can it look at our knowledge base questions and answer them? I think that part is the most easily doable, and that's the part where everyone starts from and goes, "We can build this out." That's not the problem. The problem is the harnesses around it. To give you an idea, we also need a translation layer. When it goes into different countries, it can translate properly. That's number one.

Second is scale. If it starts to hit that level of scale, can you build that in-house? Now, if you build that in-house, that takes a lot of time and

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effort, and that's not easy. Third, is all the features that come with it, so your simulations, your testing harness, all of that is built in. That takes a lot of effort to build in. Your then processes, your procedures that you need to build in, not that you need to build the procedures, but you need to build a framework to support building out those procedures for the team as well. That's not easy to build.

Reporting and analytics, you need to build that out. That part, I feel like that part and chat support are the easiest. Those are the first, call it, layers that everyone takes on, then admining it, making sure it fires properly. Your error logging has to be really good. What happens if it is an error logging? Who reacts to it? It becomes a human issue once again as well. What else? There is then the authentication side of it. That's going to be interesting.

There is a lot more things **that are nuanced** that you don't realize once you start to get into it. You are like, "Hold on. We were looking at it as an iceberg." I think that's the best analogy I can give you is anytime anyone goes, "We can build it," they're looking at the tip of the iceberg at that point. It's probably the easiest thing to build, and you're like, "Let us take that on."

There is a full iceberg underneath it that needs to be taken care of as well, especially, I would say, with core things that are core to your business. If **you mess up your support, you can really hurt your business**. At some point, you go, is it really worth it, or do I pay? That's where you're better off just paying someone else because it's going to be cheaper, and it's going to be better as well.

Client 00:26:16

That makes sense. I know we're running up on time, but maybe one more question. How far do Decagon's capabilities extend into resolution? Has it been able to handle 80% of your chats, or do you still need a relatively large team behind it for things like payment issues?

Expert 00:26:37

We're above 60% range right now. It's pretty healthy. We're going to get up to 70%-75% because I think we're working on a couple of AOPs that are going to give us the comfort that we need to get there.

Client 00:26:51

That answered it. How much of your spends proportionally is going to humans versus now that you are able to automate?

Expert 00:26:59

Got it. That's the part that I want to talk about. Our internal support hasn't gone down because our internal support has been more for handholding and being really for our premier things. Our external vendors have gone down maybe 75% over the last two years.

Client 00:27:18

Got it. External vendors, is that your offshore resources?

Expert 00:27:23

Our offshore resources. It makes **it cheaper for us** because they were handling most of the tier one tickets, which Decagon handles really well.

Client 00:27:33

That makes sense. Maybe final question just to wrap this up, apologies for going over, I know you talked about the top four being here, do you see Decagon staying in front of the pack moving forward in, call it, five years from now?

Expert 00:27:49

Yes. I think they're making some really good bets at the moment.

Client 00:27:54

I am asking you to look into your glass ball, but that's helpful.

Expert 00:27:59

That's what I'm trying to figure out. In all fairness, I'll also caveat is I don't know what's going to happen within the next two years because things are changing so dramatically. If things are in the current pace, **I do think Sierra and Decagon and Fin, are in a very good spot**

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from a chatbot support perspective.

Client 00:28:18

Makes all the sense in the world. Thank you so much. We really appreciate the time, and have a great rest of your day.

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